

OCD

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Two Kinds of Insanity

When the viewpoint embodied in a disturbance of one's sanity is one's own viewpoint, that disturbance is *ego-syntonic*, meaning that it is in alignment with, not opposed to, the ego of the subject whom it afflicts. An example is the schizophrenic's belief that the President is personally monitoring her phone conversations.

When the viewpoint embodied in such a disturbance is alien to that of afflicted party's ego, it is *ego-dystonic*, meaning that it is opposed to, and not in alignment, said ego. An example is the obsessive-compulsive person's compulsion to ritualize, even though he knows there to be no objective reason for doing so. The obsessive-compulsive does not *judge* his obsessions and subsequent compulsions to be irrational. He *experiences* them as being irrational.

The schizophrenic's ability to distinguish between fantasy and reality has been damaged. The obsessive-compulsive's ability to make this distinction *has* been damaged, but his ability to do the things that he knows to be demanded by reality *has* been damaged. It is his will, not his judgment, that has been damaged.

What the schizophrenic and the obsessive-compulsive have in common is a fundamentally infantile outlook. Each has retained the narcissism of the infant, even though each has the intellect of an adult. The schizophrenic's ego

is *also* the ego of this still very much alive inner infant. As a result, his ego has two distinct and incompatible outlooks, and it therefore has no coherent way of processing information. The obsessive-compulsive's ego is *not* identical with that of the infant within him, and this is way his ego, unlike that of the schizophrenic, has no trouble distinguishing between fantasy and reality. But because there are two egos within the obsessive-compulsive, both competing for the reigns of agency, the obesssive-compulsive cannot *act* rationally, even though he can *think* rationally.

In general, an ego-syntonic illness is an inability to *think* rationally, and ego-dystonic illness is an inability to *act* rationally.

A Dialogue concerning OCD

Max: Dr. K, People with OCD suffer from both obsessions and compulsions. How are such a person's obsessions related to his compulsions?

Dr. K: Good question, Max. Obsessive beliefs are pseudo-beliefs, and compulsive acts are pseudo-acts.

Max: Please explain, Sir.

Dr. K: If a given person obsesses about his hatred of so and so, that is because he is not yet done with so and so. He is still attached to that person. But since he will not admit that fact to himself, this lingering attachment is represented in his consciousness as obsessive hatred.

If someone obsesses about the idea that someone is listening in on his phone calls, it is because he fears that no one cares about him.

If someone is obsessed with such and such, it is because what he really believes is the opposite of such and such.

In general, if someone obsessionally believes that such and such, it is because what he actually believes is the opposite of such and such. Thus, obsessional believe is pseudo-belief:

Max: In what sense is compulsive action pseudo-action?

Dr. K: If one compulsively does such and such, it is because one's real intention is to do the opposite of such and such. If a given person

compulsively avoids his ex-girlfriend, it is because he wants to see her. He is afraid that if he runs into her, he will succumb to temptation and reactivate the relationship.

Or, to take another example, consider the son who compulsively dotes on his mother. This person actually hates his mother. If he wholeheartedly loved her, he would be able to tend to her without feeling compelled to do so. But since he does not wholeheartedly love---since, in fact, a part of him utterly hates her---he must be compulsively loving.

Max: As opposed to *actually* loving.

Dr. K: Exactly. He must *dote* on her, instead of simply being an appropriately attentive son.

Max: I think I am beginning to understand, Dr. K. Compulsive love is actually hatred.

Dr. K: Yes, but it is *unconscious* hatred.

Max: What happens when it becomes conscious?

Dr. K: What happens is that any associated compulsions vanish.

Max: I see.

Dr. K: You see, Max, the essence of OCD is ambivalence. The compulsively doting son both loves and hates his mother. He loves her, and therefore feels obliged to have lunch with her on Sunday. But he also hates her and, if given half a chance, will find a way to avoid lunching with her.

Because he loves his mother, his desire not to have lunch with her must express itself circuitously. Perhaps he shows up late for his lunch date. Or perhaps he shows up two hours early, so as to hedge against the possibility of his not showing up at all.

Max: I see. He may be compulsively on time—hyper on time, as it were—as a way of insulating himself against his wish not to show up at all.

Dr. K: Precisely. And it is because of this emotional polarity within him that the obsessional engages in what Freud refers to as ‘doing and undoing.’

He does a given thing. Then he undoes it. And then undoes his undoing of it. He starts driving to his mother's house for his obligatory weekly lunch date. When he is halfway there, he realizes that he left his wallet at home. So he goes back and gets his wallet. But when he is walking back to his car, he wonder whether he left the sink running. So he goes back inside. And so on and so forth.

Max: Or perhaps he fears that he left the stove on, and that is what compels him to put off his drive to mother's house.

Dr. K: That is a good example. A very realistic example, actually. What made you think of it?

Max: It just seemed appropriate, given that the situation concerns libido.

Dr. K: Please clarify, Dr. K.

Max: Suppose that this doting son actually has a girlfriend. And what he really wants is to ditch mom, so that he can spend time with his girlfriend. In that case, his fear about the stove represents his undischarged libido.

Dr. K: Very good, Max! The stove represents *undischarged* libido.

Max: Exactly. And that's how his libido will remain if he spends the day with mother, instead of with his girlfriend.

Dr. K: And notice that his fear about the stove is actually a desire.

Max: I don't follow.

Dr. K: What he *wants* is for the stove to explode. The stove represents his passionate desire for his girlfriend. His 'fear' the stove will explode is really his desire that *he*---meaning his genital region---will, so to speak, 'explode.'

Max: Very clever.

Dr. K: And his doing and undoing----his on-again/off-again behavior---itself represents his undischarged libido.

Max: I vaguely understand, but some clarification would help.

Dr. K: When he first heads out to mother's, he is doing. When he turns around, he is undoing.

The doing part of his behavior represents his love for his mother. The undoing represents his antipathy towards.

Max: I think I understand. The compulsiveness that characterizes his behavior represents a stalemate between his love and his hatred. If he loved her more than he hated her, he would simply 'do', that is, he would simply drive there, without having to double back. And he simply hated her, he would simply *not* do, that is, he would simply not head out to be begin with. But neither emotion has the upper hand, so he both does and undoes, thereby allowing each emotion to express itself.

Dr. K: Admirably well put, Max. But the strongest emotional force within this person is not his love for his mother; nor is it his hatred.

Max: What is it then?

Dr. K: His manly desires are far stronger than both his love and his hatred for his mother. So far as his mother is still relevant to his emotional life, it is in the sense that she interferes with it. And his doing and undoing---his heading out to mother's house, then turning around, then turning around again---mirrors the sexual act. The piston-like repetitiveness of his driving behavior is a way of doing what he would *really* like to be doing but---thanks to mom—he is not doing.

Max: So his driving is an analogue of the sexual act.

Dr. K: Yes. And notice your choice of word: his *driving* behavior.

Max: I see! His back and forth car-driving is a proxy for another kind of back and forth driving.

Dr. K: Exactly.

Max: But you said that his back-and-forth driving had to do with his ambivalence about his mother.

Dr. K: It does. And it also has to do with his undischarged libido.

Max: So it is ‘overdetermined’, to use another expression of Freud’s.

Dr. K: Precisely.

Max: But actually, sir, if you dig beneath the surface of this story, his behavior is *not* overdetermined. I mean, it is overdetermined at one level. But at another, deeper level, it has only one determinant.

Dr. K: I am intrigued, Max. Please explain your meaning.

Max: As you yourself said, Dr. K. this hypothetical person’s passions cannot possibly burn for his mother. But his mother can certainly drive a wedge between him and his girlfriend. And assuming that his mother is a manipulator---as she obviously is, since she would not otherwise have such an emotionally busy relationship with her grown son---it stands to reason that she does everything she can to stymie her son’s relationship with his girlfriend.

Dr. K: This is very interesting, Max. Please continue.

Max: This old woman profiles as a jealous ex-beauty queen, rather like the mother in Snow White. Assuming that this hypothetical we are discussing is at all true to life, this woman is unfulfilled. You will notice that the father is conspicuously absent from the picture, either in the sense that he is a weakling who is simply unable to give her what he wants or the sense that he is, quite literally, absent.

Dr. K: The picture you are describing is clinically accurate, Max. Please continue. This is fascinating.

Max: Because this woman is unfulfilled---because there is an emptiness inside where there should have been a man’s love---she tried to turn her son into a little husband.

Dr. K: Or tried to do so, but had only limited success.

Max: That is exactly what I was just about to say.

Dr. K: If this old woman had actually emasculated her son—if she had

broken him---he would not be conflicted. He would simply drive to mother's house, like the good little boy she wanted him to be. But he can barely get himself to go, that being why, when he does finally go, he does so in such a conflict-ridden, compulsive manner.

Max: I know we're discussing a hypothetical, but this all rings so true.

Dr. K: Because it is. Please continue, Max. Please explain to me the sense in which this person's behavior is ultimately *not* overdetermined.

Max: Right. What he really wants is to be with his girlfriend. His feelings concerning his mother are secondary. To be sure, he is indeed conflicted about his mother, and that does indeed have a hand in driving-related doing and undoing. But what he *really* wants to be doing is 'doing' his girlfriend, if you'll forgive me the pun.

Dr. K.: And it's a good pun, because it isn't really a pun. He wants to be doing and undoing his girlfriend. As in, he wants to do—meaning, enter---and undo---meaning withdraw—and then do again.

Max: Right. But his mother, through her machinations, is preventing that. Assuming, as we are, that this story is true to life, she has thrown all kinds of monkey wrenches in the relationship. Perhaps she has turned his son's girlfriend against him, making herself out to a kindly old woman, who merely wants to spend a little time with her son, and making him out to be a self-centered bastard, who will not so much as spend an hour or two with his dear old mother, if it means foregoing gratification of his petty lusts.

Dr. K: He is making the son out to be what the absent father was.

Max: Either that, or she's making out the son to be what she falsely made out the father to be.

Dr. K: Touché.

Max: Anyway, he really wants to be with his girlfriend. But his mother has prevented that, or at least momentarily scuttled it. So he discharges his urges symbolically, with his car, by driving back and forth. As for his ambivalence towards his mother---yes, that is indeed operative in his

behavior. But it merely determines the exact form that his behavior takes. Given that he is ambivalent towards his mother, his symbolic re-enactment of the sexual act is expressed in terms of the doing and undoing that he is in connection with his weekly drive to mother's. But what his behavior is *really* about is the aforementioned sexual act---the one that he is not being allowed to carry out, thanks to his mother's meddling.

At the same time, given that he is not having relations with his girlfriend, he is inevitably going to displace his libido in some way or other, and, such displacements being what they are, he is likely to discharge his urges through behavior that 'shadows' the sexual act.

So at the end of the day, this is really about his sexual frustration, and it is only secondarily about his ambivalence towards his mother.

Dr. K. Agreed, Max. But there isn't really any disagreement between us.

Max: How do you mean, Dr. K?

Dr. K: What I mean is that the forces that you just described are constitutive of his ambivalence towards his mother, and they are therefore determinative of his ambivalence-mediated driving-related doing and undoing.

Max: I do not follow.

Dr. K: This young man obviously is not consciously aware of his mother's treachery. But he is aware of it. He probably does not quite see it for what it is, even at the level of unconsciousness. But he is surely aware of it. How could he not be? How could he not find his mother's meddlesome behavior irritating? And how could not at some level see it for it what it is? And how, therefore, can his doing and undoing on the road not be an expression of rage on his part towards his mother---rage towards her for coming between him and the gratification of his manly desires?

Max: I think I understand. So even though I am right to say that, ultimately, his behavior has only determinant, this being his sexual frustration, you are also right to say that his behavior is a function of his ambivalence towards his mother. He is ambivalent towards his mother because she is causing him to be sexually frustrated. So his ambivalence and

his sexual frustration are, at least in this context, operating as a single cause.

Dr. K: Admirably well put, Max.

Max: Earlier you said that obsessive actions are pseudo-actions.

Dr. K: Yes. Compulsive acts are to normal acts what obsessive beliefs are to real beliefs.

Max: You said that earlier, but I still do not entirely understand what you meant.

Dr. K: The man in our story doted on his mother. He did so compulsively. The reason is that he wanted to do the opposite. His actual motivation was the opposite of his supposed motivation. So his behavior was counterfeit behavior.

Max: Sir, why don't we give this fellow a name? Let's call him "John," just to simplify exposition.

Dr. K: Good idea. Proceed.

Max: It seems to me that your position embodies a failure to distinguish between desires and intentions. It may well John's *desire* to harm his mother or, in any case, to *not* to be with her on Sunday. But that does not mean that he did not *intend* to harm her or that he *intended* to not be with her. He very clearly *did* intend to her, assuming that he does eventually make to her house for Sunday brunch. And we may indeed make that assumption, given how often it is that people comply with social obligations that they very much would like to spurn. In any case, a counterfeit action cannot possibly be one that in some ways embodies a desire to do the opposite: for by that measure, almost all actions carried out in social contexts, would qualify as pseudo-actions. A counterfeit act would be one that was driven by an *intention* to do the opposite. But the concept of such an action is of doubtful coherence, and in any case John's actions do not, by that measure, qualify as counterfeits.

Dr. K: You are quite right to distinguish between desires and intentions. Intentions are grounded one's personality. Desires need not be so grounded. There are free floating desires: desires that are in one, but not *of* one.

That said, the concept of a counterfeit intention is a coherent one, and counterfeit intentions very much do exist. And the intentions driving compulsive actions are indeed of this kind.

We have been considering John's actions in a rather abstract way. In actuality, the end-result of a compulsively performed action is the opposite of the consciously intended result---and therefore coincides with the *unconsciously* intended result.

Max: So supposing that John's acts of kindness towards his mother are compulsive, they don't affect her in the same way as actual acts of kindness?

Dr. K: Correct. They affect her in the same way as acts of hostility. For that is what they are.

Max: I think I understand. John is obsessively concerned with his mother's health. So he compulsively takes her to doctor after doctor. This demoralizes her and wears her down. her morale plummets, which depresses her immune system.

Dr. K: Spot on, Max. And perhaps John also puts her on such a strict diet that she ends up being malnourished. And he is supposedly so concerned for her safety that he doesn't let her go to parties. Her morale plummets, and her immune system follows suit.

Max: And it's all because John unconsciously hates his mother.

Dr. K: Right. And it should be made clear that John is not driven by sadism, at least not of the conscious variety. John's conscious intention really is to help his mother.

Max: But his *unconscious* intention is to harm her.

Dr. K: Exactly. And it is his unconscious intention that carries the day.

Max: So it isn't exactly that John's compulsive acts of kindness are completely fraudulent. It is rather that they are fraudulent *relative* to John's conscious intentions authentic *relative* to his unconscious intentions.

Dr. K: That's a good way of putting it. But there is still some sense in which those actions are unqualifiedly fraudulent.

Max: Explain.

Dr. K: John's conscious it not purely pretextual. It has fairly deep roots in John's values, even though it has shallow roots in his desires. By the same token, John's unconscious intention has relatively shallow roots in John's values, even though it has deep roots in his desires. Do you follow me thus far, Max?

Max: I do, Dr. K, but I do not see where you are going with this.

Dr. K: An 'action', for lack of a better word, that has no roots in values is not an action at all. It is an instinctual *re*-action---a reflexive pseudo-action. Where there is desire without values, there is passion---in both the contemporary and the etymological senses of the word---but not action. True agency is about the fulfillment of ideals---not necessarily ethical ideals, but ideals of some kind or other---and where there are no values there are *ipso facto* no ideals. Do you follow Max? I realize that this not exactly easy material.

Max: I actually do follow you, Sir. In fact, it is actually ringing a few bells. Desire-driven acts that do not embody values have the authenticity of veritable actions, but not the requisite sublimity, and value-driven acts that do not embody desire have the requisite sublimity of veritable actions.

Dr. K: Well put. The former are real, but they aren't actions. The latter are actions, but they aren't real.

Max: So they *aren't* actions.

Dr. K: That's right, Max. Now do you see why compulsive actions are pseudo-actions?

Max: I almost see it, but I need you to nudge me in the right direction.

Dr. K: Actual actions must embody beliefs as well as desire. But also

necessary that the values in question be in alignment with the desires in question. The second condition is not satisfied in John's case. John's values want him to be good to his mother. John's desires want him to be evil to his mother. So his desires and his values are at odds with each other. As a result, each of John's compulsive acts of kindness consists of two distinct half-actions. One of those half-actions is all about instinct. The other is all about values. To borrow your own turn of phrase, Max, the former is real but is not an action, whereas the latter is an action but is not real. So these compulsive acts aren't really anything.

Max: I see. And even though those actions, for lack of a better word, do discharge Max's hatred of his mother, it isn't Max who is doing the discharging. It is rather that his sadism is leaking out of him.

Dr. K: Well put.

Max: And although the beneficent side of Max's behavior is entirely intentional, it so completely lacks the support of his desires and of his emotional side that it almost fails to be *his* behavior. It is almost more appropriate to describe it as behavior that he *undergoes* than it is to describe it as behavior that he *engages* in.

Dr. K: And given how deracinated his values are---how lacking in any instinctual basis---it is less appropriate to describe them as values that he has than it is to describe them as values that *have him*.

Max: Very good, Sir!

Dr. K: So now you see that John's compulsive actions are counterfeit actions. To the extent they are real, they aren't actions, and to the extent that they are actions, they are not real.

Max: The same being true of all compulsive actions.

Dr. K: Correct.

Neurotic Anxiety as Rational Fear: A Dialogue

Paula: Professor, is there such a thing as irrational anxiety?

Dr. K: No, there is not. There is such a thing as *displaced* anxiety. But all anxiety is justified.

Paula: Please explain.

Dr. K: Oftentimes there is something that a person is deeply anxious about, but he does not want to admit what that thing is. When that happens, he displaces his anxiety about that thing onto some other thing.

This second thing is relatively innocuous: it is not something that warrants the level of anxiety he is experiencing. And this is the very reason that he chooses to displace his anxiety onto this thing.

Given that his anxiety is out of proportion to this second thing, it seems to be irrational. But it is not irrational, since it is the first thing, not the second, that it is its real object.

Paula: I think I know what you are talking about. I found reason to believe that my boyfriend was cheating on me. I really didn't want to believe, because my relationship with him was very valuable to me.

I then started having the most intense obsessions. For a little while, I was obsessed with the idea that my accountant was ripping me off.

Then I became fixated on the idea that I was going to die of a brain tumor, caused by cell phone use, even though I don't use my cell phone all that often.

Then I became obsessed with my diet. I became convinced that the produce I was eating was loaded with pesticides, which were causing nerve damage.

And then it was some other thing that I became obsessed about---and then, few days later, yet another thing.

Dr. K: Were there any persistent obsessions?

Paula: There was one. I was obsessed with the idea that my boyfriend was going to die of a heart attack. That one lasted for a while.

Dr. K: When did it end?

Paula: When I caught him in bed with my roommate.

Dr. K: Wow.

Paula: Then I wanted him to die.

Dr. K: What you just described is typical. You had an obsessional fear that your boyfriend was going to die. But in actuality this is not what you *feared*: it is what you *wanted*. And because you wanted it, your fear had to assume the form of an obsession. Had you actually feared your boyfriend's death---had it *not* been something that you unconsciously wanted---this fear of yours would have been obsessional in nature.

Paula: Explain that last point, Professor.

Dr. K: Obsessive fear is unconscious desire. Obsessive belief is unconscious disbelief. The unfulfilled woman who is obsessed with the idea that her phone is tapped actually *wants* her phone to be tapped; she *wants* people to pay attention to her.

Mafiosos whose phones really *are* being tapped are proverbially *unconcerned* about what they say over the phone. To be sure, they try, with some success, to exercise due caution. But they are not *obsessed* with the idea that their phones are being tapped. Rather, they are dispassionately aware of the possibility---the very real possibility---that their phones are being tapped. And their awareness is oftentimes *too* disaffected, *too* non-obsessive, that being why they often slip up egregiously.

In any case, their fear that their phone is tapped is non-obsessional, for the very reason that it is indeed a *fear*, and not a desire.

Paula: I still do not quite follow you, Professor.

Dr. K: This unfulfilled woman cannot admit to herself how lonely and unhappy she is. Her vanity would not allow that. So she cannot consciously tell herself, 'I am so unhappy: How I wish people cared enough to listen in my conversations!' For it is not simply desire for love and companionship that she is experiencing: it is also mortal shame at her situation. She sees herself as a failure, for the reason that she is not the object of a man's love. Therefore, she can admit her desire for companionship into consciousness *only* on the condition that it is represented as its opposite: her *desire* to be paid attention to---to be the object of someone else's interest---is permitted

entry into her conscious *only* on the condition that it is experienced as *fear* that she is being paid attention to.

Paula: I am beginning to understand. I once read a case by Freud, in which he discusses a female patient of his who was obsessively afraid that there was a man hiding underneath her bed. She feared that, when she closed her eyes to go to sleep, this man would leap out from the under the bed and *stab her*.

This woman was red-blooded and passionate; and, apart from this obsession of hers, she was quite sane. When Freud apprised her of the true meaning of her obsessions---when he revealed to her that she *wanted* a man to be 'stab' (i.e. sexually penetrate) her---he fear gave way to conscious longing and sadness.

And---correct me if I am wrong---you are saying that my 'fear' that boyfriend was going to die was to be understood in similar terms. I *wanted* him to die. But I could not admit this desire of mine into consciousness, since the reason for my hatred of my boyfriend was my belief---my knowledge, I should say---that he had humiliated me by cheating on me. If my reason for wanting him to die were simply that he was despicable---if it weren't predicated on my belief, my painfully embarrassing belief, that he had betrayed me so badly---then I wouldn't have had any resistances to experiencing my hatred of him consciously. But it *was* so predicated and therefore was *not* consciously acceptable, except on the condition that it be experienced as its opposite.

Do I understand you correctly, Professor? Is this indeed what you are saying?

Dr. K: It is precisely what I am saying, and given how well you have articulated my position, and how aptly you have illustrated it, I cannot help but feel that you agree with me.

Paula: I do. But there is one thing that I do not understand.

Dr. K: What is that?

Paula: Why does this unfulfilled woman's desire have to assume *any* conscious form? Why can't it simply remained buried in the conscious? Why does it have to enter consciousness, if only under the guise of its opposite?

Dr. K: For the reason that it is much too powerful to remained unconscious. Powerful instinctual drives must be discharged, in one way or another. If, for whatever reason, the subject is on his guard against a given instinctual drive of his---if he refuses to cop to it---it will discharge itself in ways that make it hard to recognize. But one way or another, it will express itself.

Paula: Very well. I see why this woman's desire has to assume the form of a fear. But why does it have to assume the form of an *obsessional* fear? Why not just a regular fear?

Dr. K: Because rational fears need to be supported by the facts. Obsessional fears do not. Consider the failed entrepreneur who is obsessed with the idea that somebody is going to torch his business. He has this obsession because, in actuality, he *wants* someone to torch his business, for the reason that it has become a burden. But he cannot admit that he has this desire without admitting that his attempt to strike out on his own was a failure.

Here's the thing. There is no legitimate reason to believe that someone is going to torch his business. This would be a problem *if* his 'fear' were cut from the same (non-obsessional) cloth as normal fears. Sane, non-obsessional fears, like the mafioso's fear that the F.B.I. is taping his phone, are answerable to the evidence: when the evidence ebbs, the fear becomes weaker; and when the evidence waxes, the fear intensifies. But the very essence of *obsessional* fear is that it is not answerable to the evidence: such a fear retains its intensity no matter how weak the external justification for it is. Thus, the failed entrepreneur can allow his desire to chuck his failed his business to assume the form of a fear *provided* that it assumes the form of an obsession, which, precisely because it *is* an obsession and therefore not a hewed to the evidence, can persist no matter how meagre that evidence is.

Paula: If you don't mind my saying so, Professor, I'm getting the feeling that *you* are this failed entrepreneur. I hope you are not offended.

Dr. K: I am not. And you are right. I was talking about myself. How did you know?

Paula: You spoke so authoritatively and passionately about this poor devil's situation that you could not possibly have been reciting mere book knowledge.

Dr. K: As I said, you are quite right. I was talking about myself. I was *consciously* doing so.

Paula: Why were you not offended when I called you out on this unfortunate fact about your life? Or were you offended, but hid it beneath a patina of equanimity?

Dr. K: No, I was genuinely *not* offended. Here's why. The business venture of mine that I was discuss, the one failed so utterly, was one that I did not really want to undertake. I felt compelled to undertake it, because I neurotically wanted to prove to myself that I could hack on the mean streets of Wall St. But at the end of the day, that simply isn't what I do. I am a thinker, not a financier. If I were a financier and failed at it, *then* I would care. The reason Salieri cared about being a mediocre composer is that he was indeed a composer. Had he been a painter or a blacksmith who, for some neurotic and therefore passing reason, was pretending to be a composer, he would not have cared, at least not in any serious way. And given that I very clearly am not Gordon Gecko, not even of the failed variety---given that what I am is someone who likes to discuss psychoanalytic matters---I am relieved, *consciously* relieved, that my attempt to be Gordon Gecko failed.

Paula: I see. Because if it had succeeded, you would be stuck having to do something you really don't want to do.

Dr. K: Exactly.

Paula: I know people who have spent their entire adult lives trying to be something they are not. And they are miserable. Their lives consist of one failure after another. You were lucky. You failed once---and only briefly, and in a rather insignificant way---and then quickly regrouped.

Dr. K: Yes and no.

Paula: How do you mean? Or is it not something worth going into in this context?

Dr. K: Actually, given what it is that we're discussing, it is very much worth going into.

Paula: Do tell! I am enjoying this conversation for some reason.

Dr. K: You are enjoying it because it's cathartic for you, because it's about getting neurotic monkeys off of your back.

Paula: Exactly. Monkeys of neurotic obligation.

Dr. K: Exactly.

Paula: Anyway, please continue with your story.

Dr. K: Gladly. I taught on a reputable college, but I hate absolutely hated the place. Frankly, I hated academia as a whole, and for very good reasons. Anyway, I resigned my professorship. And I was so bitter towards the Academy---and so *rightly* so, frankly---that I initially wanted to something that was as far removed as possible from the sort of work I did as a professor.

So I undertook a series of entrepreneurial ventures, each of which involved my spending most of time working with machines---this sort of work being antithetical to what I had done as a professor.

Anyway, I developed intense and persistent obsessions to the effect that somebody was going to vandalize my machines. There was no objective reason to believe this. It was not particularly valuable machinery, and even if it had been, my circumstances made it unlikely that anyone would steal it or vandalize it.

But I nonetheless was obsessed with the idea that hooligans would pour sand in it, or some such.

And, of course, you know why I had this obsession.

Paula: Because that is what you wanted. You wanted to be done with all of those god damned machines.

Dr. K: Exactly.

Paula: What ended up happening with those machines?

Dr. K: I finally copped to the fact that I did not want to be in that line of

work, and when that happened, I *wanted* somebody to come and torch those machines. Which is more or less what ended up happening.

Paula: Really?

Dr. K: At first I tried to sell them. But nobody would buy them. I couldn't even give them away. Eventually I just had them hauled off. And even though I had to spend money to junk them---even though I did not recover so much as one dime of my initial investment---I was nothing short of elated when I saw them being hauled off.

Paula: That's a good story.

Dr. K: And it gets better. After I admitted to myself that I wanted to resume my career as a scholar and that I really, really did not want to be working these machines, there was a period of a few months when I actually had trouble finding people to come and haul of my equipment away. It was rather heavy equipment; it had sustained a fair amount of damage, thanks to my amateurish attempts to use it, and therefore wasn't very valuable; and, having blown all of my capital on this failed business venture of mine, I didn't have the money to hire people to get rid of it.

Anyway, during the two month period when I literally could not pay people to take this equipment away, I developed an intense fear that people would *not* come and get rid of these machines. So now I feared the opposite of the thing I had previously feared. And this new fear of mine was as intense as my the opposing fear that it displaced. But *this new fear mine was not an obsessional fear: it was a rational fear*. The point being that, just as I have been saying, my previous obsessive fear that people would vandalize my equipment was really a desire that this very thing happen----that, to generalize this point, obsessional fears are unconscious desires.

Paula: Bravo, Dr. K! Bravo!

Can OCD Be Treated Without Medication?

ULTIMATELY, THERE IS NO OTHER WAY TO TREAT IT.

MEDICATIONS, SPECIFICALLY SSRI'S ARE ENORMOUSLY USEFUL AS AN *ADJUNCT* IN THE TREATMENT OF OCD. BUT OCD IS ABOUT EMOTIONAL CONFLICT. THE COMPULSIONS ARE ABOUT DOING, ALBEIT IN A DISTORTED WAY, WHAT ONE WOULD LIKE TO DO BUT WILL NOT PERMIT ONESELF TO DO. (THE COMPULSIONS INVOLVE MUTED OR OTHERWISE WARPED EXPRESSIONS OF SEXUAL OR VIOLENT URGES. HENCE THEIR REPETITIVE AND, IN THEIR MUTED WAY, VIOLENT NATURE.) THE OBSESSIONS---THE OBSESSIVE FEARS, SPECIFICALLY---ARE DISPLACED DESIRES. THE OBSESSIVE FEAR THAT SO AND SO WILL DIE OR THAT SUCH AND SUCH A CATASTROPHE WILL HAPPEN IS A DISPLACED DESIRE THAT SUCH AND SUCH WILL HAPPEN. TO THE EXTENT THAT ONE CAN 'GET OVER' OCD, ONE DOES DO SO BY RE-INTEGRATING ONESELF WITH ONE'S DESIRES. THE OBSESSIVE-COMPULSIVE PERSON'S SYMPTOMS ARE 'EGO-DYSTONIC', AS OPPOSED TO EGO-SYTONIC, MEANING THAT OBSESSIVE-COMPULSIVE DOES NOT IDENTIFY THEM; IN OTHER WORDS, HE SEES THEM AS IN HIM BUT AS NOT AS *OF* HIM. AND THE WAY FOR THE OBSESSIVE-COMPULSIVE TO STOP HAVING OCD IS FOR HIM TO MAKE HIS 'SYMPTOMS' EGO-SYTONIC; IN OTHER WORDS, HE MUST MAKE THEM *OF* HIM, AS OPPOSED TO JUST *IN* HIM. ONE MUST DISTINGUISH OCD *PER SE* FROM THE ARCHITECTURE---THE OFTEN HYPER-FUNCTIONAL COGNITIVE ARCHITECTURE---THAT GIVES RISE TO OCD. OCD DOES NOT ITSELF ENHANCE PERFORMANCE; BUT IT IS THE PATHOLOGICIZATION OF STRUCTURAL PROPERTIES THAT ARE CONDUCTIVE TO EXTREME

ABILITY AND HIGH LEVELS OF PERFORMANCE.

IT IS INCUMBENT ON THE OBSESSIVE-COMPULSIVE NOT TO 'ELIMINATE' OR 'AMPUTATE' HIS OBSESSIVE-COMPULSIVE ENERGIES, BUT TO CHANNEL THEM IN A PRODUCTIVE DIRECTION (OCD PEOPLE TEND TO BE GOOD AT, AMONG OTHER THINGS, LAW, PHILOSOPHY, ENGINEERING, MUSIC, AND, WITH SOME QUALIFICATIONS, PSYCHOANALYSIS. THEY ARE NOT AS GOOD AS POLITICS OR PURELY SOCIAL THINGS, THOUGH EVEN THAT IS SUBJECT TO HEAVY QUALIFICATIONS.)

GIVEN THE HEAVY-DUTY ANXIETY AND DEPRESSION THAT IS OFTEN---IF NOT TYPICALLY---ASSOCIATED WITH OCD, SSRI'S ARE *DE RIGUEUR* AT CERTAIN JUNCTURES. BUT IT MUST BE REMEMBERED THAT THEIR THERAPEUTIC SIGNIFICANCE---THEIR VERY CONSIDERABLE THERAPEUTIC SIGNIFICANCE---IS SUBORDINATE TO THE PSYCHOLOGICAL REMODELLING EARLIER DESCRIBED (THAT IS, TO THE RE-INTEGRATION OF THE SUBJECT AND THE DESIRES FROM WHICH HE IS NOW ALIENATED AND WHICH, BECAUSE HE IS ALIENATED FROM THEM, MAKE THEIR WAY BACK INTO HIS CONSCIOUSNESS THROUGH THE SUBTERFUGES OF COMPULSIONS ACTION AND OBSESSIVE DOUBT). THUS, THE SSRI'S LIFT THE DEPRESSION THAT INHIBITS THE PROCESS OF RECONCILING THE SUBJECT TO HIS OWN VALUES AND DESIRES AND, THEREBY, DISINHIBITS THE PROCESS OF RESTORING THE INTEGRITY OF THE SUBJECT'S PERSONALITY-ARCHITECTURE.

Neurosis vs. Psychosis

Psychosis is a mental impairment that is precipitated and sustained by a break with external reality. Neurosis is a mental impairment that is precipitated and sustained by a break with one's emotional condition.

The neurotic flees from his emotions; the psychotic flees from reality. Neurosis may lead to a blunting of one's awareness of certain aspects of external reality, but any such loss of awareness is subordinate to loss of awareness of one's emotional condition.

Similarly, psychosis may lead to a disruption of one's understanding of one's emotional condition, but any such disturbance is subordinate to the psychotic's loss of awareness of external reality.

Though symmetrical in the just-described respects, neurosis and psychosis are ultimately not mirror images of each other. This is a consequence of the fact that psychosis involves a *partial* regression to a condition of psychological infancy, the operative term being "partial." An infant is not psychotic. The reason is that the infant's psychological integration is not simultaneously that of an adult and an infant; it is simply that of an infant. For this reason, the infant's psychological condition is integrated and healthy, even though the infant's understanding of reality is even more subjective, and therefore more *projective*, than that of the adult psychotic.

The adult psychotic, on the other hand, has the psychological architecture of an adult as well as that of an infant. Therefore, the psychotic has two entirely distinct and incompatible ways of processing information. He does not have a unified value system; he does not have a unified understanding of how to implement such values as he has; and his psychological condition is therefore one of utter disarray. And therein lies the peculiarly damaging nature of psychosis.

Nothing comparable holds of the neurotic. Neurosis is about containing threats to one's integration by repressing them. To repress a conceit is not to bury one's knowledge of it in the unconscious; it is rather to bury one's knowledge of its emotional valence in the unconscious. As a result, the neurotic's condition is one of relatively unimpaired intellectual awareness.

In fact, in some circumscribed ways, it may be even be a condition heightened intellectual awareness, owing to the fact that the neurotic is likely to compensate for his impoverished emotional state by hypercathecting his intellect. Moreover, by stripping the contents of

consciousness of their emotional valences, the neurotic guarantees that he has a hyper-stable, though also an ossified psyche.

The essence of psychosis is an inability to organize consciously experienced emotion; the essence of neurosis is an inability to *have* consciously experienced emotion. The former is paralyzed by a superabundance of emotion, the latter by lack of it.

Compulsive Work

Compulsive Work is about avoidance. Here one must distinguish between two kinds of workaholics. There is the workaholic who loves what he is doing: this person works because he wants to work. Then there is the workaholic who hates what he is doing: this person works because he doesn't want to work. The workaholic who loves his work is not working compulsively, and this form of workaholism is not about avoidance. But the workaholic who hates his work *is* working compulsively, and this form of workaholism *is* about avoidance. This type of workaholic is avoiding doing what he wants to do, and because he hates what he is doing, he has to do it compulsively.

Obsessions and Compulsions

When one is obsessively afraid of something, that is because one really wants that thing to happen. The son who is morbidly preoccupied with the idea that his father will cut off his trust fund, even though there is no reason to believe this to happen, really wants his father to cut him. He is ashamed of being dependent on his father, and deep down wants to be free and strike out on his own.

To give a personal example, I was morbidly afraid that my dissertation adviser would die of a heart attack. I remember that, at the time, I used to joke with my girlfriend about how I wanted this to happen, but those jokes were only jokes---or so I told myself. My adviser turned out to be incredibly malicious, and I had to switch dissertation advisers.

In any case, I knew all along that he was ill willed, but initially, before I switched advisers, I was dependent on him, so I did not want to admit this to

myself. So my desire that he die of a heart attack had to remain unconscious. Once I ceased to have any dependence on him, my actual feelings became conscious.

After I switched advisers, everything worked out. It was enormously difficult at first, since I had to start my dissertation from scratch, and I also had to write it in a completely new area. But I wrote it in three weeks, and in the process new intellectual and professional vistas opened up for me.

The point is that when I was obsessively afraid that my first adviser would die, my unconscious was trying to tell me something. But it could not tell me directly, since I didn't want to hear what it was trying to tell me. So it had to express itself circuitously, through what Freud calls a *negation*.

A negation is a case of letting one's real feelings into consciousness only on the condition that they negated. Here is an example. You and a lawyer friend of yours are discussing your careers, and she says, without any prompting from you, "I know what you're thinking: you think I hate being a lawyer. You think I want to quit and do something else. Well, you're wrong. This is definitely what I want to do. Yes it is."

What this person is saying is: "I really hate being a lawyer. I hate it so very, very much. God, I hate being a lawyer." But she can't admit it to herself. After all, she's locked in, or at least believes herself to be. She spent three years in law school; she may have spent several years practicing law; and she may not know what else to do.

She won't admit her real feelings to herself, so when those feelings rise to the surface of her psyche, she hastily slaps a big "not" on them, to make sure she doesn't see them for what they are.

A lot of religious fanaticism consists of negation. When people are hysterical about their religious beliefs, that is because they aren't their real beliefs. Fanaticism is a way of containing doubt.

Extreme views are often cases of negation. People who have extremely puritanical views about sex are, without exception, people with extremely intense strong libidos; and people who have extreme views about alcohol---who think that it is the root of all evil and should not be tolerated---are people alcoholics who yearn for a drink but know they mustn't succumb to this temptation.

Compulsions are negations that are expressed in action. I will give an example from my own life. For a while, I tried to make money working with

machines. I had no aptitude for what I was doing and no real desire to do it. But I would work for days on end with these machines, sometimes going without sleep. I would not let myself stop working.

And the reason is that if I had let myself stop working, my real feelings would have flooded to the surface. Which is eventually what happened, and it was incredibly liberating.

The reason my machine business failed so utterly is that I never really wanted to do it in the first place, and that is also why, when I was doing it, I had to do in such a compulsive manner. It's also why all of that work yielded nothing. It yielded nothing, because my unconscious motivation---my *real* motivation---was to *not* to what I was doing. The reason I was compulsive in efforts to get this business off the ground was that my real motivation was to put it in the ground.

People ask how they can free themselves from OCD.

A first step is to know the following truths.

Obsessions are negations. If you are obsessively afraid of such and such, that is because what you *want* is such and such.

Compulsions are negations that are being acted out. If you compulsively to such and such, that is because what you really desire, and what you are really trying to accomplish through your compulsive actions, is the opposite of such and such.

The reason people obsess is that they don't admit their real feelings to themselves. And the reason they don't admit their feelings to themselves is that, if they did, they would have to do a lot of hard work. They would have to change their lives, and themselves, which is the hardest kind of work. And their compulsive work—their endless hours at the law firm or their endless hours doting on the ailing parent whom they secretly hate----are pseudo-work: they are laziness expressed as work. These people are too weak and lazy to do the hard thing, which is to change, so they do the easy thing, which is to keep doing the same thing, even though it doesn't work, but to do so much of that thing that it appears as though they are working.

The good news is that, if you actually make those changes, instead of remaining on your treadmill of compulsion, it turns out to be far easier than you thought. You are no longer fighting yourself, and everything falls into place.

You would not admit your true feelings into consciousness, so you had to

negate them. Because your real feelings were so intense, you had to redouble those negations; so those negations became obsessions. But your obsessions were not enough to contain your real feelings, so those obsessions became compulsions. The reason those compulsions are so unpleasant is that you really want to do the opposite.

So *do it*. Don't *fight* yourself. *Be* yourself.

You obsess when you believe the opposite of what you consciously believe. You act compulsively when you do the opposite of what you are really trying to do.

The compulsion is a compulsive cover-up. You are trying to bury your real feelings. And you are trying to bury them because you are weak and lazy. But your life would be easier, and you would have less to be afraid of, if you copped to your feelings. A life of obsessions and compulsions quickly leads to oblivion and is itself oblivion.

So the way to get over OCD is simple: *Do what you want to do*.

When you do what you are compelled to do, you are doing the opposite of what you want to do.

Read *Totem and Taboo*, by Sigmund Freud, where the role of negations and compulsions in the construction of morality and other social institutions is expertly explained.